



Playing the Periphery

A thesis submitted for the degree of MA
Games Design by

2441871

Font: Arial or Times New Roman.

Double line spacing, except for indented quotations and footnotes.

Quotations of 40+ words or 4+ lines: separate indented text blocks w/o quotation marks.

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Abstract

My topic of interest lies at the intersection of paratextual, corporeal, and sociocultural aspects of iconic game titles and their impact on the industry's history. Paratext consists of surrounding media not included in the game itself but strongly influencing how the experience is accessed, framed, and understood. Material comprises the physical means and contexts of play, in turn shaping the experience through sensory input, physical feedback, and presence. Society and culture permeate the above two aspects: while paratextuality is encoded in media and materiality is embedded in technology, the sociocultural layer is embodied by players themselves through their shared habits, beliefs, and informal systems. The co-operation of this trinity is flavoured by the aesthetics of the game playing experience in its entirety.

My project poses the following question:

In what ways can contemporary game design achieve holistic aesthetic experiences in the likeness of iconic, historically acclaimed game titles?

The research perspective is mostly aimed at context awareness and experiential revision, although, nostalgia remains a latent yet potent factor that bears investigation.

Retrospective settings are being highlighted because most well-known titles from the past represent history as written by the victors.¹ With this in mind, I believe that game design can notably benefit from closely examining the external circumstances which frame any media product's release.

The theoretical research will examine existing frameworks established in game and media fields of study, intending to touch on fields and concepts such as experiential aesthetics, affect theory, procedural rhetoric, immersion, metagaming, preservation, and various design approaches. The practical review will survey an assortment of games whose play experience is notably characterised by contextual circumstances. This investigation is meant to derive patterns from exemplary case studies that can suggest ways of implanting the external layers of play experience into a new piece of playable media. With historical awareness providing the background, some of the findings will be incorporated into designing a digital artifact complementing the written one, accompanied by fictional context in the shape of lore and paraphernalia.

Comprehensive analysis of multiple real world scenarios is to be followed by a selection of applicable² approaches, which in turn will inform the directions taken throughout the design and development process. Concurrently, any relevant observations should be recorded with the intent to feed back into the writing and, eventually, provide a strong basis for reflection. Exercising theory in practice is expected to direct the unfolding of the game's design. The goal that I aspire to achieve with this project is tracing a model of media creation that is elevated by its surrounding context, and also aligns with key values established in my personal game design philosophy (GD5609, 2025), then put the resulting framework into future practice.

¹Or, in a few amusingly infamous cases, the kitschy underdogs and dark horses that are often both cautionary tales and subjects of cult following. Evidently, if one struggles to attain immortality via glory, becoming an anecdote remains a viable alternative.

²A word which here means (Snicket, 1999) "feasible".

Chapter 1

Introduction

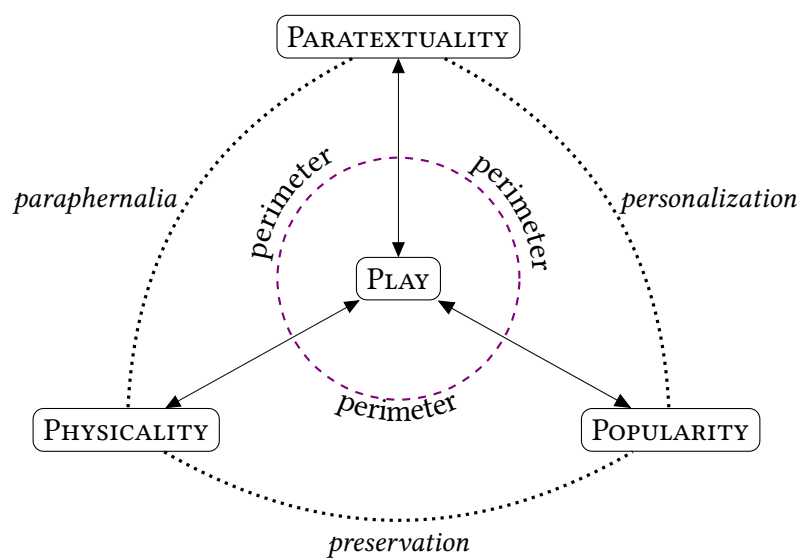


Figure 1.1: Peripheral aspects of play

Declaration of research topic and question

their field and relevance to game studies

Clarify vocabulary 'holistic'

Pitch practical part

Connect to written part

Overview of primary and secondary titles

Chapter 2

Literature Review

Define key terminology

contextualise the P-trinity through secondary sources

Friedrich Adolf Kittler versus Marshall McLuhan (McLuhan, 1964) on media theory

Mechanisms: New Media and the Forensic Imagination, a book by M.G. Kirschenbaum (2012)

“Platform Studies: Frequently Questioned Answers”, a conference paper by Ian Bogost and Nick Montfort (2009)

“Social Realism in Gaming”, an article by Alexander Galloway (2004)

Metagaming: Playing, Competing, Spectating, Cheating, Trading, Making, and Breaking Videogames, a book by Stephanie Boluk and Patrick Lemieux (2017)

Digital Playgrounds: The Hidden Politics of Children’s Online Play Spaces, Virtual Worlds, and Connected Games, a book by Sara Margaret Grimes (2021)

“The Cultural Field of Video Game Production in Australia”, an article by Brendan Keogh (2019)

Always Already New: Media, History, and the Data of Culture, a book by L. Gitelman (2008)

Confronting the Challenges of Participatory Culture: Media Education for the 21st Century, a book by Henry Jenkins (2009)

Play Between Worlds: Exploring Online Game Culture, a book by T.L. Taylor (2009)

2.1 Paratextuality

The initial concept by Gérard Genette (1997) has been considerably expanded to better fit the field of game studies, and as a result has been entangled with adjacent terms from the original scholar's typology.¹ However, both approaches can be integrated into my own, owing to the generous overlap between the three types of external context.

When strictly categorising cases, Genette's definition regards "Elements that form a figurative threshold of a text and ground it in a socio-historical context. [...] must be created by the text's producers or their associates". These can be promotional materials, introductory sequences, menus, credits, making-ofs, contextual information about authors.

While preserving Genette's wording on which elements are included, Consalvo's interpretation assigns "...no limitations on authorship or cultural status" (2007). This is akin to *cultural epiphenomena* and allows consideration of more media like "criticism and journalism, user discussions, fan fiction and fan art, streaming, trans-media storytelling" (Švelch, 2020).

On these grounds, Genette's delineation is the more clear and straightforward directive for labelling purposes, while Consalvo's expansion on it draws a connection to cultural assimilation. Additionally, both have ties to materiality in their manifestation.

2.2 Physicality

proper lit review

The most tangible of the three aspects, this refers to all the material conditions in which the game is played. Exclusively, this covers authentic hardware and peripherals, physical data storage, haptic features, and environmental settings. In addition, paratextual supplements in physical format, e.g., paper, fall under the same category to form paraphernalia.

2.3 Popularity

proper lit review

Culture and society permeate the first two aspects via informal systems of shared habits, beliefs and conventions. The formation of social rituals by the demographic over time leads to emergent paratext, stemming from reception and circulation, and physical aspects are embodied in player presence and direct interaction with the hardware.

¹The five aspects of *transtextuality* comprise of: *inter-*, *meta-*, *hyper-*, *archi-*, and *para-*texts.

Chapter 3

Case Studies

Frame real-life settings in the context of paratextuality, physicality, and popularity

Media archaeology, theoretical framework application, ludic and paratextual analysis, comparative synthesis

Curate a subset of primary sources

Support with secondary sources

“Reality has Always Been Augmented: Play and the Promises of Pokémon GO”, a book by Miguel Angel Sicart (2016)

Fan-based zines and archives, e.g., Your Sinclair, Commodore User, Compute!, Antic, etc.

The Internet Archive / The Wayback Machine (1996)

Chapter 4

Development

Chronicle research through design

Explain how in interrogating the question via prototype design, theory informed practice and vice versa

Recognise any setbacks or limitations.

Primary sources that inspired direction:

Space Invaders loading mini-game

Sims x2 cases

UFO50

Daniel Mullins Games, 2021

Vectrex

Guidance from reading: *Making deep games: Designing games with meaning and purpose*, a book by Doris C. Rusch (2017)

4.1 The Lost AMOLED

Clever Rebel Trials was an ambitious attempt to reinvent platform exclusivity following the 4th Generation's Console Wars. Rather than developing a killer app for a designated system, Adelin Melony (1970-2002) set out to create a machine whose sole purpose was to play the one game that it was optimised for. The game itself was released in 1997 on the Ludic Entertainment Device - its dedicated Generation 4.5 console that was soon dubbed "Addie Mel's One-Shot LED", shortened to AMOLED. While the approach is not unheard of (being a standard practice for arcade cabinets and many 1st and 2nd generation products) such an idea carries major risks concerning scope, audience demand and reception.

CRT is set in a retro-futuristic world with competing factions offering exclusive membership perks. The main gameplay loop revolves around managing a multitude of characters from the Clever Rebels Team. Each rebel specialises in a very narrow field of studies, which makes for entirely different character builds and run strategies.

Notes from the GM The creator's names are anagrams using the first names of Daniel Handler, whom she also shares a birthday with, and his pseudonym Lemony Snicket. Chronologically, her lifetime closely matches the birth and growth of videogame technology, but was sadly cut short when she was only 32 years old.

Although they have been swapped and scrambled into vague equivalents, most names within this alternate universe originate from the ASOUE books.

cite

In them, there are also mentions of a secret organisation called VFD. In Snicket's world VFD stands for Volunteer Fire Department, but in ours, among other things, it means Vacuum Fluorescent Display. I found the notion of using other display type acronyms amusing, hence CRT and LED/AMOLED.

Beside having a name reminiscent of NES, the LED console with its CRT game came out at a time of a literal dimensional shift in computer graphics technology - a transition from 16-bit pixels on cartridges to 32-bit polygons on optical discs with all the new rendering and memory management methodologies it brought about. ¹

Skill trees progression: List studies/disciplines and what each excels and fails at

Setting within the fictional layer (worldbuilding comes later)

C. Narrative & World Structure (Backstory as Architecture)

Historical scope larger than the game itself

Mention key institutions, past crises, and unresolved events

Identify known unknowns

Events everyone references but noone explains fully

Long-dead figures whose actions shape the present

Conflicting records or interpretations

Define branching allegiance paths (conceptual)

factions/institutions

Each has internal logic, incomplete worldview, and ethical trade-offs

¹It also may or may not conveniently share a birthyear with yours truly.

4.2 Periphery

4.3 Prototype

Layout & UI:

screens correspond to hand placement: left hand collects water, right hand steers the truck
controls were "canonically" separate dials (and/or even meant for two players?)
here they are tied to a single mouse which is why each is confined to a single axis
loading bar tracks the mini-game's progress under the hood
maybe our goal can be to have the player ignore the launch button once it appears
tips serve as ambiguous clues to what the main game is about; juicier details come later on

Environment:

Trees at varied grown stages spawn over time. The bigger the tree:
the more likely it is to spawn small trees around itself
the more flammable it is, but generates larger clouds
Raindrops fall at the same speed but appear faster from larger clouds
right now mouse buttons serve as pedals for the fire truck
already seems a bit tricky to multitask, I may automate movement
truck and bucket upgrades for successful fire management

"1-Bit Pack"; "Adore64"; "Flowerwall CRT Shader for Godot"

ASSET
HUNT:
back-
ground?,
cursor?,
loading
bar, steer-
ing wheel,
sounds and
animation



Figure 4.1: "Paper" prototype

title screen

tree growth stages

adult trees produce saplings

forest coverage -> cloud size

cloud size -> raindrops amount

correct car controls

auto-pilot fire-truck

upgradable bucket

wireframe
with legit
software

auto-collecting bucket

score -> loading progress

full bar -> start button to end game

4.3.1 Paraphernalia

Paratextuality + Physicality

The material artefacts and design elements that mediate player engagement.
Talk about the manual with regards to gameplay

4.3.2 Preservation

Physicality + Popularity

Describe the hardware quirks dials, 2 screens?

The state of survival, degradation, and community efforts to archive or interpret the game.

Map the technical state of preservation

Confirm what game components survived

Detail physical media formats and archival status (cartridges, discs, hardware dependencies)

Write about the reasons and impact of loss

Technological transition between gaming generations as a cause

Hardware obsolescence and toolchain abandonment

How incomplete preservation shapes player experience and community memory

4.3.3 Personalisation

Paratextuality + Popularity

How community interpretations and practices shape legacy.

Position as cult classic, revered for atmosphere and design philosophy

Discuss how the game is remembered more than played

Explore how ambiguity fosters community creativity and personal meaning-making

4.4 Product

Why does the mini-game exist? Calibration for both platform and player Checking controls work properly while getting used to them and learning tip&tricks

H. Dissertation Integration (not fictional)

A reflective section linking the games

Mini-game as implemented theory

Lost game as designed absence

Ambiguity as holistic aesthetic strategy

Explicitly justify incompleteness

As methodological choice

As historical simulation

As aesthetic design

Chapter 5

Synthesis

Revision of the artifact

Discussion on theory in practice

how the two informed, or clashed with, each other

Correlation with primary sources

Provisional answer to the research question.

Secondary sources that share concerns with the artifact

Chapter 6

Conclusion

Reflect critically on what has been achieved

Outline implications and further open-ended research directions to build upon.

Recommend reading/playing not mentioned in earlier chapters

Final word count minus references, footnotes and appendices

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Appendix A

Paratexts

A.1 Manual

gameplay manual

hardware manual

A.2 Articles

A.2.1 Magazine preview

Magazine preview article

A.2.2 Webpage review

Webpage review article

A.3 Message board(s)

scaffold HTML page

fill thread with comments